PP-B-2120B
May 31, 1991
SUPERSEDING
PP-B-2120A
June 10, 1985

FEDERAL SPECIFICATION

GROUND BEEF PRODUCTS, FROZEN

This specification is approved by the U.S. Department of Agriculture for use by all Federal agencies.

1. SCOPE AND CLASSIFICATION

1.1 Scope. This specification is for the procurement of frozen ground beef products.

1.2 Classification. The product shall be one of the following types as specified in the procurement data:

Type I	-	Ground Beef, Bulk
Type II	-	Ground Beef and Vegetable Protein Product, Bulk (combination of ground beef and vegetable protein product)
Type III	-	Ground Beef Patties
Type IV	-	Beef Patties (combination of ground beef and vegetable protein product formed into patties)
Type V	-	Coarse Ground Beef, Bulk

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 Government publications. The issues of the following documents, in effect on date of invitation for bids or solicitation for offers, form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein:

Federal Specifications

PPP-B-636 - Boxes, Shipping, Fiberboard

PPP-F-320 - Fiberboard; Corrugated and Solid, Sheet Stock (Container Grade), and Cut Shapes

FSC 8905

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U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA)

Meat and Poultry Inspection Regulations

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Superintendent of Documents, U.S. Government Printing Office, Washington, DC 20402-0001.)

U.S. Standards for Condition of Food Containers
Visual Aids for Inspection of Rigid and Semirigid Containers

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Chairperson, Condition of Container Committee, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Room 2506, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456.)

USDA, AMS, Livestock and Seed Division, Meat Grading and Certification Branch, Instruction 918-2, Rev. 10, G-16

(Application for copies should be addressed to Livestock and Seed Division, Meat Grading and Certification Branch, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Room 2628, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456.)

Cereal Panel Odor and Flavor Evaluation System

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Northern Regional Research Center (FR-USDA), 1815 North University, Peoria, IL 61604.)

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2.2 Other publications. The following documents form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise indicated, the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or solicitation for offers shall apply:

Association of Official Analytical Chemists

Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Association of Official Analytical Chemists, 2200 Wilson Boulevard, Suite 400-CD, Arlington, VA 22201-3301.)

American Public Health Association

Compendium of Methods for the Microbiological Examination of Foods

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Public Health Association, 1015 15th Street, NW, Washington, DC 20005.)

National Motor Freight Traffic Association, Inc., Agent

National Motor Freight Classification

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Trucking Associations, Inc., Traffic Department, 2200 Mill Road, Alexandria, VA 22314.)

Uniform Freight Classification Committee, Agent

Uniform Freight Classification

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Uniform Classification Committee, Suite 1120, 222 South Riverside Plaza, Chicago, IL 60606.)

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 Source of commodity. The meat shall be from cattle slaughtered in, and the finished product shall be prepared and handled in, an establishment regularly operated under the Meat and Poultry Inspection Regulations of the U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) except that packed, boneless meat which has been initially accepted for use in the product may be frozen and stored in commercial cold storage warehouses.

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3.2 Material.

3.2.1 Meat. Beef shall be the only meat ingredient used and shall be derived from any portion of fresh-chilled or hot-processed carcasses. (Unless specifically allowed by the purchaser, calf and/or veal shall not be considered to be beef for purposes of the specification.) Noncarcass components (e.g., cheek meat, head meat, ox tails, esophagus, hearts, and by-products), kidney fat, cod or udder fat, and hanging tenders are not allowed. Detached cutaneous muscles shall be limited to not more than 10 percent of the product. Also, trimmings, or any pieces weighing less than 0.5 pound (227 g), shall not exceed 10 percent of the total weight of the product prior to grinding. Beef destined for use in the product shall be in excellent condition; i.e., exposed lean and fat surfaces shall be of a color and bloom typical of meat which has been properly stored and handled. Cut surfaces and naturally exposed lean surfaces shall show no more than slight darkening or discoloration due to dehydration, aging, and/or microbial activity. The fat shall show no more than very slight discoloration due to oxidation or microbial activity. No odors foreign to fresh meat shall be present. Changes in color and odors characteristically associated with vacuum-packaged meat in excellent condition shall be acceptable. Also, the meat shall show no evidence of freezing, defrosting, or mishandling.

Boning and trimming. All meat shall be made boneless and the following parts shall be excluded:

a. Bone.

b. Cartilage.

c. Backstrap (ligamentum nuchae).

d. Calcified periosteum.

e. The heavy sheet of abdominal tunic between the muscles of the flank.

f. Tendons of shoulder clod and knuckle not cut flush with the surface of the lean.

g. Heavy connective tissue:

- Opaque connective tissue found between the bottom round and the knuckle (silver skin), gracilis membrane, and opaque periosteum.

- Sacrosciatic ligament found in the top sirloin and anterior portion of the outside round.

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- Heavy connective tissue on the surface of the lower (ventral) edge of the short plate and flank.

- The membranous portion of the diaphragm. Membranous covering from the skirts and abdominal section of the short plate.

- The membranous covering of the flank (rectus abdominis).

h. The tendinous ends of shanks and bottom round to a point where a cross-sectional cut exposes at least 75 percent lean tissue.

i. Prescapular, prefemoral, popliteal, and any exposed lymph glands.

NOTE: Contractor's are advised to implement a quality control program designed to measure production quality of boneless beef prior to grinding. The AMS agent will verify product quality as prescribed in section 4.4 Examination for boneless meat.

Except for hot-processed meat (meat derived from cattle slaughtered on the same day as processing), all eligible meat shall be initially certified for condition. Examination for condition requirement shall be as specified in 4.3 Examination for excellent condition. Following the condition certification, (at the contractor's option) any portion of the meat may be excluded in any combination, provided the remaining product is in compliance with all the material requirements. All meat shall be made boneless and may be frozen and stockpiled for later use. Hot-processed meat may be derived from any portions of the carcass that meet the material requirements and shall be ground on the same day of slaughter.

3.2.2 Vegetable protein product (VPP). (Unless otherwise specified by the purchaser, the source of VPP shall be soy.) When Types II and IV are specified by the purchaser, the VPP (soy) must comply with the following requirements:

a. Unless otherwise specified, any one or combination of the following types of VPP may be used; the minimum protein content (as is basis) shall be as follows:

Type	Protein (as is basis)
Flour	50.0 percent
Concentrate	65.0 percent
Isolate	85.0 percent

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When a combination of the above types are produced by the VPP manufacturer, the amount of each type and minimum protein content (as is basis) of the mixture shall be declared on the manufacturer's label.

b. VPP shall be dry, and the moisture content shall not exceed 8.5 percent (as is basis).

c. The ash content of the VPP shall not exceed 6.0 percent (as is basis).

d. The fat content of the VPP shall not exceed 1.0 percent for flour and concentrate (as is basis) or 0.1 percent for isolate (as is basis).

e. Unless otherwise specified, the physical characteristics of VPP, in the dry form, must be either granular or textured and comply with the following sieve size requirements:

	At least 95 percent shall pass through:	Not more than 10 percent shall pass through:
Granular:	U.S. Standard No. 14 sieve	U.S. Standard No. 60 sieve
Textured:	U.S. Standard No. 4 sieve	U.S. Standard No. 18 sieve

VPP (of any texture) which has been hydrated by the VPP manufacturer may be used provided that: (1) the product is frozen; (2) the protein content (as is basis) of the hydrated VPP is stated on the manufacturer's label.

f. Unless otherwise specified, the flavor characteristics of the VPP shall: (1) receive a flavor score of 6.0 or higher when tested in accordance with the provisions of the USDA Northern Regional Research Laboratory Odor and Flavor Intensity Scoring Scale of the Cereal Panel Odor and Flavor Evaluation System; and (2) have no additional flavor added.

g. Unless otherwise specified, the microbiological characteristics shall: (1) not exceed a maximum Total Plate Count of 25,000/gram; and (2) have Salmonella negative in 25 grams. The microbiological characteristics shall be determined in accordance with the latest

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edition of the Health and Human Services, Food and Drug Administration, Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM) published by the AOAC.

The purchaser may specify additional requirements or optional ingredients such as amino acids, vitamins, and minerals; however, the purchaser must specify the requirements of each optional ingredient.

When USDA, Food and Nutrition Service (FNS) requirements are specified, the biological quality of the protein in the VPP shall be at least 80 percent that of casein, determined as approved by FNS. In addition, the VPP must contain the following levels of nutrients per gram of protein:

Nutrient	Minimum
Vitamin A (IU)	13.00
Thiamine (milligrams)	.02
Riboflavin (milligrams)	.01
Niacin (milligrams)	.30
Pantothenic acid (milligrams)	.04
Vitamin B6 (milligrams)	.02
Vitamin B12 (micrograms)	.10
Iron (milligrams)	.15
Magnesium (milligrams)	1.15
Zinc (milligrams)	.50
Copper (micrograms)	24.00
Potassium (milligrams)	17.00

Compliance with the requirements specified for VPP and other optional ingredients shall be determined from the manufacturer's product label attached to the product. However, the AMS agent in cooperation with the purchaser maintains the right to verify that the VPP complies with the specified requirements by conducting analyses in AMS laboratories in accordance with the latest edition of the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists (AOAC) or other testing procedures as specified.

To ensure compliance with FNS requirements, the manufacturer's label attached to such products must include the following certification:

"This product meets USDA-FNS requirements for use in meeting a portion of the meat/meat alternate requirements of the child nutrition programs."

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3.3 Processing.

3.3.1 Handling and storage. Except for hot-processed meat, meat that is less than 28°F (-2.2°C) or higher than 50°F (10°C), will not be accepted for initial certification. Handling and storage of certified boneless meat prior to processing into the finished product shall be in accordance with one of the following methods as declared to the Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS) agent by the contractor. Unless otherwise specified, boneless meat handled by any of the following methods may be combined in any combination and processed into the finished product. Product failing to meet the following temperature requirements will be rejected and cannot be reoffered.

a. Same-day Processing. Fresh-chilled meat processed on the same day of initial certification shall not exceed 50°F (10.0°C) at any time up to and including placement into the freezer.

b. Fresh-chilled Storage. Fresh-chilled meat not processed on the same calendar day of initial certification may be held up to 72 hours from the time the container holding boneless meat is sealed by the AMS agent, provided the meat does not exceed 40°F (4.4°C) at the time offered for grinding. However, if the temperature of the meat at the time offered for grinding exceeds 40°F (4.4°C), but is less than 50°F (10°C), that meat may be processed on the same calendar day provided it is reexamined for condition in accordance with the stationary lot reexamination criteria in Table I of 4.3.2. The meat shall not exceed 50°F (10°C) following grinding up to and including placement into the freezer.

Fresh-chilled boneless meat destined for use in the finished product, but held for more than 72 hours from the time the container holding boneless meat is sealed by the AMS agent, shall be reexamined for condition in accordance with the stationary lot reexamination criteria in Table I of 4.3.2. at the time of further processing, provided the meat does not exceed 40°F (4.4°C).

c. Same Day Production of Certified Frozen and Tempered Beef Products. Miscut beef steaks, miscut diced beef, and/or trimmings derived from previously certified meat which has been frozen and tempered to facilitate slicing, dicing, or trimming may be further processed into ground beef. However, this product shall be ground on the same calendar day of slicing, dicing, or trimming and shall not exceed 40°F (4.4°C) at the time offered for grinding. The meat shall not exceed 50°F (10°C) following grinding up to and including placement into the freezer.

Dry ice or liquid nitrogen may be used to maintain the above temperatures.

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d. Frozen Storage. Fresh-chilled meat not processed on the same calendar day of initial certification may be frozen and stockpiled for later use provided it is processed not more than 60 days from the initial certification date. The boneless meat shall be frozen to an internal temperature of 0°F (-17.8°C) or lower within 72 hours following the time the container holding boneless meat is sealed by an AMS agent. Boneless meat assigned to freezing shall be stored at 0°F (-17.8°C) or lower and packaged and packed in commercial containers that are adequate to maintain product excellence during freezer storage. Containers shall be labeled as "Boneless Beef for PP-B-2120". Examination for frozen temperature requirements shall be as specified in 4.7.1 72 hour frozen temperature requirement.

The meat shall be maintained frozen during storage, and the internal temperature shall not exceed 40°F (4.4°C) when further processing is resumed.

e. Hot-Processed Meat. The temperature of meat ground on the same calendar day of slaughter shall not exceed 50°F (10°C) after final grinding, up to and including placement into the freezer. Previously certified fresh-chilled or frozen meat may be added prior to final grinding. Dry ice or liquid nitrogen may be used to obtain the required temperature prior to final grinding.

3.3.2 Hydration. The VPP shall be hydrated as follows: To determine the maximum amount of water to be mixed with the dry, or previously hydrated, frozen VPP to provide 18 percent protein in the mixture, the following equation shall be used:

$$\left[\frac{\text{Percent protein (as is basis)}}{18}\right] - 1 = X$$

X = maximum pounds of water to be added to each pound of dry product.

The VPP shall be hydrated for the length of time listed on the VPP label. If this information is not available, the VPP shall be hydrated until all water is absorbed. The hydrated VPP must be used in the same calendar day in which it was hydrated. VPP hydrated and frozen by the soy manufacturer may be used provided that: (1) the protein content of the hydrated product (as specifically stated on the manufacturer's label) is not less than 18.00 percent; (2) the product may be tempered, but not thawed, prior to use; and (3) additional water may not be added directly to the meat.

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The purchaser shall specify the maximum percent of hydrated VPP in the combined finished product. If no amount is specified, a maximum of 20 percent hydrated VPP shall be allowed in the finished product.

3.3.3 Grinding and blending. The grinding and blending process shall be a continuous operation. The boneless meat shall be ground at least once through a plate having holes no larger than 0.75 inch (3/4 inch or 19.1 mm) in diameter (or it may be otherwise reduced in size provided the texture and appearance of the product after final grinding is typical of ground beef prepared by grinding only). Final grinding shall be through a plate having holes 0.125 inch (1/8 inch or 3.2 mm) in diameter and shall be accomplished immediately following the initial reduction(s) in size. Grinding equipment used must have sharp knives and plates. In addition, except for Type V, a bone collector/extruder system shall be used on the final grinder to remove objectionable material (bone, connective tissue, etc.) which may be present in the raw materials. Material removed from the product by the bone collector/extruder system may not be reintroduced into the product. The AMS agent shall routinely check the collector/extruder system to assure that it is operable and removing objectionable material.

The meat may be blended subsequent to each reduction in size. When a combination of ground meat and VPP, Type II or IV, is specified, the hydrated VPP shall be blended with the raw beef following the initial reduction in size. The ground meat shall not be blended after final grinding.

Type V (coarse ground) product, shall be ground once through a plate having holes no larger than 1.0 inch (25.4 mm) and no smaller than 0.625 (5/8) inch (15.8 mm) in diameter. Alternatively, the boneless meat may be ground twice, with the smallest plate having holes no larger than 1.0 inch (25.4 mm) and no smaller than 0.75 (3/4) inch (19.1 mm) in diameter. Grinding equipment used must have sharp knives and plates. The meat shall be blended after grinding or between grinds to assure uniformity of fat content throughout the lot.

3.3.4 Fat content requirements. The fat content shall be determined by chemical analysis and shall be based on 4 samples from each production lot. These analyses shall be conducted in AMS laboratories and shall be made in accordance with the latest edition of the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists. Unless otherwise specified, the fat content shall be as follows:

a. For products containing only beef (Types I and III), production lots shall be rejected if: (1) the fat content analysis of one or more of the individual sample units is less than 12.00 percent or more than 26.00 percent; and/or (2) the average fat content analysis of the 4 sample units exceeds 21.00 percent. For coarse ground beef (Type V) the production lot will be rejected if the average fat content exceeds 21.00 percent.

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b. For products which combine ground beef and VPP (Types II and IV), production lots shall be rejected if: (1) the fat content analysis of one or more of the individual sample units is less than 12.00 percent or more than 24.00 percent; and/or (2) the average fat content analysis of the 4 sample units exceeds 19.00 percent.

NOTE: The purchaser may specify discount ranges.

3.3.5 Bacteriological requirements. When specified by the purchaser, ground beef will be analyzed for bacteria levels in accordance with the latest edition of the Health and Human Services, Food and Drug Administration, Bacteriological Analytical Manual, published and distributed by the Association of Official Analytical Chemists. The product sampled shall be analyzed for psychrotropic plate count levels not exceeding 1,000,000 bacteria per gram. Vendors will be responsible for costs of bacteriological testing, which will be conducted at an AMS Laboratory. Testing and actions against product exceeding 1,000,000 bacteria per gram are specified in 4.8.3 Bacteriological sampling and testing.

3.3.6 Patty weight. When ground beef patties or beef patties are specified, the purchaser shall specify the weight of patties desired. Patty weights shall be verified as prescribed in section 4.10 Patty size verification.

3.3.7 Patty shape. Immediately following the final grind, the ground beef must be mechanically formed into approximately uniform round patties, unless otherwise specified.

3.3.8 Plate size thickness. Unless otherwise specified, the patty forming plate must measure not less than 0.375 inch (3/8 inch or 9.5 mm) nor more than 0.438 inch (7/16 inch or 11.1 mm) in thickness.

3.3.9 Freezing. All ground beef products shall be placed into a freezer within four (4) hours after acceptance by the AMS agent. Product shall be frozen to an internal temperature of 0°F (-17.8°C) or lower within 72 hours after acceptance of the lot by the AMS agent. Examination for frozen temperature requirements shall be as specified in 4.7.1 72 hour frozen temperature requirement.

The internal temperature of the product must be 0°F (-17.8°C) or lower at the time the delivery unit is offered for final certification out of the freezer. Examination for frozen temperature requirements shall be as specified in 4.7.2 Final certification frozen temperature requirement. The contractor shall assure that the truck or rail car in which the product is to be shipped is mechanically refrigerated and capable of maintaining a temperature of 0°F (-17.8°C) or lower during shipment.

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NOTE: If, at any time after initial certification, the AMS agent observes meat which is in less than excellent condition or in noncompliance with other specification requirements, the agent shall reject the involved lot.

3.4 Metal detection. All ground beef shall be subjected to testing for the presence of metal contamination. Testing must be conducted after grinding but may take place before or after patty formation and/or packaging. For bulk ground beef (Types I, II, and V), and for stacked patties (Types III and IV) or patties tested after final packing, the vendor shall install and operate equipment capable of detecting the presence of a 3.0 mm, 440 stainless steel test standard. For patties (Types III and IV) tested in single patty layers before final packaging the equipment used must be capable of detecting the presence of a 1.5 mm, 440 stainless steel test standard. Testing procedures are detailed in 4.6 Testing of metal detection equipment.

4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Contractor's responsibility. Examination and certification by AMS shall not relieve the contractors of their obligation to deliver a product complying with all the requirements of this specification. The contractor shall assure product compliance prior to submitting it to AMS for any examination.

4.2 Examination and supervision. Product acceptability shall be determined by an AMS agent. In accordance with Meat Grading and Certification Branch Instructions, the local meat grading supervisor will determine the degree of supervision necessary to assure specification compliance. The cost of all grading and certification services performed by the AMS agent involving examinations, supervision, official documentation, related services (including samples for fat content analyses and charges for such analyses), and travel and mileage charges, when applicable, shall be borne by the contractor.

4.3 Examination for excellent condition. Fresh-chilled bone-in or boneless meat shall be examined for excellent condition (as described in 3.2.1) using either the 100 percent or stationary lot examination procedure. However, when lean is removed from bones subsequent to the initial boning operation, such product shall be examined for condition prior to further lean removal using the stationary lot examination procedure. Determination of wholesomeness and acceptability of meat with respect to the presence of foreign material (e.g., glass, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, or metal) shall be made by a Meat and Poultry Inspection Operations (MPIO) employee.

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The procedure used shall be specified by the contractor and agreed to by the AMS agent. Lot/sublot sizes shall be as defined for each procedure. However, the AMS agent reserves the right to declare as a lot a portion of a declared lot if, in the agent's opinion, that portion may indicate gross noncompliance with any of the specification requirements, or if production is seriously interrupted.

4.3.1 100-percent. This procedure may be used to examine fresh-chilled bone-in or boneless meat for excellent condition criteria (as described in 3.2.1) provided the meat is in portions of at least 3 pounds (1.4 kg). Boneless meat in portions less than 3 pounds shall be examined by the stationary lot method (4.3.2).

4.3.2 Stationary lot. This procedure may be used to examine fresh-chilled bone-in or boneless meat of any size portion (cuts and/or trimmings) for condition requirements. Except for the last lot of the day, the lot size, as declared to the AMS agent by the contractor, shall be not less than 1,500 pounds (680 kg). The sampling plans for meat are listed in Table I. The randomly selected sample units shall be a minimum of 12.0 pounds (5.4 kg) of adjacent meat and shall be evaluated for compliance with the excellent condition criteria (as described in 3.2.1). Lots containing product in less than excellent condition shall be rejected and cannot be reworked and reoffered.

TABLE I. Stationary lot sampling plan

Lot size pounds (kg)	Sample size (number of sample units)	Sample size (for reexamination)	Defects Ac	Re	Reexam. 1/ Ac	Re
15,000 or less (6,803.9 kg or less)	20	32	0	1	0	1
over 15,000 (over 6,803.9 kg)	32	50	0	1	0	1

1/ - Applicable to fresh-chilled meat held for further processing (Refer to 3.3.1 b.).

4.4 Examination for boneless meat. By offering beef for grinding, the contractor certifies that it meets the requirements specified in 3.2.1 Boning and trimming. The AMS agent shall monitor and sample boneless beef as prescribed below. In addition, if the AMS agent observes meat which is in gross noncompliance with these requirements, the involved production lot shall be rejected.

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4.4.1 Product monitoring. At least two times each calendar day the AMS agent shall examine a single sample of at least 60 pounds of adjacent meat randomly selected from the boneless beef available for grinding. Additional samples may be examined when boneless meat from different suppliers is offered or if the AMS agent has reason to believe that the level of product quality has changed significantly from previous samples. The boneless beef shall be evaluated for compliance with the defect classifications listed in Table III. If not more than two defects are found in a sample, product monitoring shall continue as prescribed above. If 3 or 4 defects are found in a single sample, a second 60 pound sample shall be selected and evaluated as prescribed above. If not more than 6 defects are found in the two samples combined, product monitoring shall continue. If 5 or more defects are found in the first sample, or 7 or more defects are found in the two samples combined, future production lots shall be examined as prescribed in 4.4.2. All product offered during product monitoring (unless rejected for gross noncompliance or condition) will be accepted for grinding, regardless of the number of defects found.

4.4.2 Skip lot inspection. Product monitoring shall be continued as prescribed in 4.4.1. In addition, the contractor should be requested to designate lots containing not less than 1,500 pounds (680 kg) of product for skip-lot examination. The AMS agent shall randomly select one lot of each 10 for examination. After each selected production lot, one of the following 10 production lots shall also be selected for examination. From each selected production lot the AMS agent shall randomly select 8 sample units. Each sample unit shall be a minimum of 12.0 pounds (5.4 kg) of adjacent meat and shall be evaluated for compliance with the defect classifications listed in Table III. If 5 or fewer defects are found, the production lot shall be accepted and inspection continued at this level until 5 consecutive selected production lots have passed. When 5 consecutive selected production lots have passed at this inspection level, product sampling shall be discontinued, and product monitoring continued as prescribed in 4.4.1. If 6 or more total defects are found, the involved production lot shall be accepted, but subsequent production shall be examined in accordance with procedures in section 4.4.3.

4.4.3 Stationary lot inspection. Samples shall be randomly selected from all production lots (minimum 2,000 pounds) as prescribed in Table II. The randomly selected sample units shall be a minimum of 12.0 pounds (5.4 kg) of adjacent meat and shall be evaluated for compliance with the defect classifications listed in Table III. Failure of the production lot to meet the acceptance criteria as identified in Table II shall cause rejection of the lot. Except for meat rejected because of evidence of freezing or defrosting or presence of meat in less than excellent condition, rejected meat may be offered for reexamination once as one stationary lot (refer to Table II,

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Reexamination). Meat shall be reworked prior to reexamination. When 5 consecutive original lots have been accepted, product shall again be examined in accordance with skip lot inspection procedures in section 4.4.3. Reworked lots will not be counted as original lots when determining level of inspection for future production.

When boneless meat is offered for certification prior to shipment to another location for grinding, inspection shall be conducted using the stationary lot procedure. In addition, at the request of the contractor, the local supervisor may approve the use of the stationary lot inspection procedure for all meat at the location of grinding. However, if a lot is rejected, the vendor may not choose to revert to product monitoring until all conditions prescribed for reversion to lower inspection levels have been met.

TABLE II. Stationary lot sampling plan 1/

Lot size (Pounds)	Initial examination Sample size (No. sample units)	Major Ac	Major Re	Minor Ac	Minor Re	Reexamination Major Ac	Reexamination Major Re	Reexamination Minor Ac	Reexamination Minor Re
15,000 or less (6,804.0 kg)	20	3	4	10	11	2	3	7	8
15,001 or more (6,804.5 kg)	32	5	6	14	15	3	4	10	11

1/ The finding of any meat not in excellent condition shall cause rejection of the lot.

TABLE III. Defect classifications for boneless meat

Defect categories Major	Minor	Defects 1/
101		Bone measuring 0.5 inch (12.7 mm) or more in one dimension and 0.2 inch (5.1 mm) or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
	201	Bone measuring 0.2 inch (5.1 mm) or more but less than 0.5 inch (12.7 mm) in one dimension and 0.2 inch (5.1 mm) in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).

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TABLE III. Defect classifications for boneless meat (Continued)

Defect categories Major	Minor	Defects 1/
102		Cartilage measuring 1.0 inch (2.5 cm) or more in one dimension and 0.2 inch (5.1 mm) or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
	202	Cartilage measuring 0.3 inch (7.6 mm) or more, but less than 1.0 inch (2.5 cm), in one dimension and 0.2 inch (5.1 mm) or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
103		Presence of backstrap (ligamentum nuchae) measuring 3.0 inches (7.6 cm) or more in one dimension and 0.5 inch (12.7 mm) or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
	203	Presence of backstrap (ligamentum nuchae) measuring 1.0 inch (25.4 mm) or more, but less than 3.0 inches (7.6 cm), in one dimension, and 0.5 inch (12.7 mm) or more in a second dimension (when measured at right angles to each other).
104		Presence of heavy connective tissue measuring 5.0 square inches (32.3 cm^2) or more.
	204	Presence of heavy connective tissue measuring at least 3.0 square inches (19.4 cm^2), but less than 5.0 square inches (32.3 cm^2).
	205	Presence of calcified periosteum measuring 3.0 inches (7.6 cm) or more in any dimension.
	206	The tendinous ends of shanks and bottom rounds to a point where a cross-sectional cut exposes less than 75 percent lean tissue.
	207	Popliteal, prescapular, prefemoral, and/or any exposed lymph gland measuring 0.5 inch or more in one dimension and 0.2 inch or more in a second dimension.
	208	Protruding tendons of the shoulder clod or knuckle not cut within 0.5 inch (25 mm) the surface of the lean.

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TABLE III. Defect classifications for boneless meat (Continued)

Defect categories Major	Minor	Defects 1/
108		Presence of noncarcass components, kidney fat, cod or udder fat, and/or hanging tender. (Each finding of one of these items in a sample shall be scored as a separate defect.)

1/ Acceptability of meat with respect to the presence of foreign material (e.g., glass, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, or metal) shall be made by an MPIO employee.

4.5 Examination for cutaneous muscle and piece size. The contractor shall assure that each batch of product is in compliance with cutaneous muscle and piece size requirement prior to submitting the product to the AMS agent. During product monitoring of boneless beef or any other examination, the AMS agent shall subjectively evaluate product for compliance with the requirements specified in 3.2.1 Meat for detached cutaneous muscle and piece size. If, in the opinion of the AMS agent, the product is (or may be) out of compliance, he/she shall weigh the amount of product necessary to determine compliance with those requirements. Product out of compliance with the cutaneous muscle and piece size requirements may be reworked and reoffered. Any cut containing more than one half cutaneous muscle in the lean portion shall be considered to be detached cutaneous muscle.

4.6 Testing of metal detection equipment. Testing for proper functioning of the metal detector shall be randomly performed at a minimum of once every hour. More frequent tests may be performed if, in the judgment of the AMS agent, the contractor's metal detector could reasonably be determined to be unreliable for any reason. Official detection test standards shall be provided to the AMS agent by the Meat Grading and Certification Branch (MGCB). The AMS agent shall follow specific testing procedures detailed in MGCB Instruction 918-2.

4.7 Examination for temperature of frozen meat.

4.7.1 72 hour frozen temperature requirement. The AMS agent will take 1 temperature reading from product in each of 3 boxes randomly selected from the lot. Any individual reading above 0°F (-17.8°C) shall cause rejection of the lot.

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4.7.2 Final certification frozen temperature requirement. For delivery units offered for final certification out of the freezer, 1 temperature reading shall be taken from product in a minimum of 3 randomly selected shipping containers. A minimum of 1 shipping container shall be examined from each production lot. Any individual reading above 0°F (-17.8°C) or any product showing evidence of mishandling, thawing and refreezing, freezer burn, or obvious deviation from specification requirements, shall cause rejection of the delivery unit.

4.8 Examination of finished product.

4.8.1 Lot. Except as otherwise specified, examinations performed for specification compliance shall be done on a production lot basis by the AMS agent.

For the purpose of this specification, a production lot is: (1) the quantity of finished product produced in the same calendar day designated by the contractor as the unit for determining compliance with specification requirements; or (2) that portion of a contractor's designated production lot which the AMS agent designates as a unit for determining compliance if, in the agent's opinion, that portion is or may be out of compliance with one or more specification requirements. Unless otherwise specified, the lot size shall be limited to the size of an offer unit as designated by the purchaser. For determining compliance with specification requirements, production lots destined for delivery on different contracts may be combined provided they are produced in the same calendar day and do not exceed the maximum specified.

All production lots shall be identified by numbering in sequence beginning with number 1. In addition, shipping containers in each production lot shall be numbered in sequence beginning with number 1.

NOTE: Production of a lot may continue into the next calendar day provided it is produced in a continuous operation.

4.8.2 Withdrawal for fat content analysis. For bulk products (Types I or II), the AMS agent shall randomly select 1 filled bag from each of 4 randomly selected shipping containers and cut from each of the filled bags 1 approximately 2-pound (907.2 g) section, the position of which was randomly established prior to the start of sampling. For Type V (coarse ground beef) the AMS agent shall randomly select approximately 2-pounds (907.2 g) of product from each of 4 randomly selected boxes of coarse ground beef from the entire lot for fat analysis. Each 2-pound section shall be independently prepared by reducing the consistency of the section to a thoroughly blended mixture. From this mixture, 3 samples shall be pulled and assigned the same identification

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number: 1 sample shall be submitted to an AMS laboratory; 1 sample shall be solidly frozen and retained by the AMS agent as a reserve sample; and the remaining sample shall be submitted to the contractor.

For patties, the AMS agent shall randomly select a stack(s) or a layer(s) from each of 4 randomly selected shipping containers resulting in 1 approximately 2-pound (907.2 g) portion of adjacent patties. Each portion shall be independently prepared by reducing the consistency of the portion to a thoroughly blended mixture. From this mixture, 3 samples shall be pulled and assigned the same identification number: 1 sample shall be submitted to an AMS laboratory; 1 sample shall be solidly frozen and retained by the AMS agent as a reserve sample; and the remaining sample shall be submitted to the contractor.

The reserve samples shall be used for analyses: (1) when the original sample is lost; or (2) if requested by AMS or the contractor. However, analysis of the reserve samples at the request of the contractor shall not be permitted unless the original analyses indicated that the involved production lot will be rejected (or discounted, if applicable) because of noncompliance with fat analysis requirements. When reserve samples are analyzed, all 4 samples shall be analyzed, and the results of such analyses shall be final. Unused reserve samples shall be returned to the contractor after final acceptance or rejection of the involved production lot.

After withdrawal of samples, the contractor shall make correct fills on the boxes sampled by adding the necessary product produced for this purpose (see 4.8.1 Lot).

4.8.3 Bacteriological sampling and testing. Sampling of product for bacteriological testing shall be conducted according to procedures detailed in MGCB Instruction 918-2 for this purpose and approved by the AMS Science Division. Two levels of sampling and appropriate actions will be followed, based on the history of the individual contractor.

a. Product monitoring. Product shall be sampled at the beginning of any production for which bacteriological testing is required. (Any stoppage of production of two weeks or more will be considered a new start-up for product monitoring purposes). Additional sampling shall be conducted on a skip-lot basis--one sample from each 40 production lots. However, contractors producing product on a continuing basis shall be tested not less often than one time a month or more often than one time a week. As long as no result exceeds 100,000 psychrotropic bacteria per gram, the contractor shall continue at this level of sampling.

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AMSC In this pavement type is commonly considered to be closely spaced crac

During product monitoring all product may be shipped, and no action will be taken against lots exceeding the bacterial requirements. However, if psychrotropic bacterial levels exceed 100,000 per gram, the contractor shall be converted to accelerated sampling upon official notification of the status change. No reserve samples will be analyzed or appeals allowed at this level of sampling.

b. Accelerated sampling. No product may be shipped until satisfactory laboratory results are obtained. All production lots will be sampled for bacteriological testing, but the AMS agent will randomly select one lot from each five (but not less than one per week for continuing producers) to send to the AMS Laboratory for analysis. The other four samples must be secured and stored under proper conditions by the AMS agent until results are obtained on the sample analyzed. Upon receipt of satisfactory results, the lots represented by the tested sample may be shipped. Any result exceeding 1,000,000 psychrotropic bacteria per gram will result in rejection of the single lot represented by that sample. Before the other lots represented by that sample can be shipped the samples from those lots must also be analyzed and passed. When five consecutive results of not more than 100,000 psychrotropic bacteria per gram are obtained under accelerated sampling, the contractor shall revert to product monitoring status. A contractor who ceases or completes production under accelerated sampling, and later restarts production with a break of less than four months, will restart under accelerated sampling as well.

4.9 Net weight requirement. Prior to product freezing, 10 shipping containers per production lot shall be randomly selected and weighed to determine the total net weight of product in the sample. Net weight shall be determined by subtracting a tare weight from the gross weight. The tare weight shall be determined by weighing empty shipping containers and packaging materials of the same kind and in the same numbers applicable to the 10 shipping containers weighed. The total net weight of the sample must be equal to or greater than the total of the marked net weights in the sample. If the total net weight of the sample is less than the total marked net weights in the sample, the lot shall be rejected. However, lots that are rejected may be reworked and submitted for reexamination (one time only). When examining resubmitted lots, 4 shipping containers per lot shall be randomly selected and weighed. The finding of any shipping container in the resubmitted lot which is less than the marked net weight shall cause rejection of the lot.

4.10 Patty size verification. Four filled shipping containers of patties shall be randomly selected from those examined for net weight (4.9 Net weight requirement.). If the selected boxes weigh more or less than 36 pounds, patties shall be removed or added (as appropriate) so that the actual net

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weight of each box is not less than 36 pounds or more than 36 pounds plus less than one patty. The number of patties in the 4 shipping containers shall then be determined and acceptance based on Table IV.

TABLE IV. Patty count - Total patties in four shipping containers

Patty size	Acceptable range
2 oz. (56.7 g)	1,140 - 1,165
3 oz. (85.0 g)	758 - 779
4 oz. (113.4 g)	567 - 586
5 oz. (141.8 g)	453 - 470

If the total patty count is less than the minimum acceptable number or greater than the maximum acceptable number, the lot shall be rejected. The purchaser may specify other patty sizes and/or acceptable ranges. When the purchaser specifies: (1) patty sizes other than those presented in Table IV and does not provide acceptable ranges in procurement documents or (2) the net weight of shipping containers packed other than specified in 5.1.2 Packing, contact the Livestock and Meat Standardization Branch, Livestock and Seed Division, AMS, USDA, Room 2603, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456 for patty count requirements.

NOTE: The purchaser may specify discount ranges.

4.11 Examination for condition of food containers. Examinations of containers shall be in accordance with the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers. The examination for primary and shipping container requirements shall be performed by the AMS agent on each production lot at the time of production prior to being placed in the freezer. In addition, an examination for condition of shipping containers shall be performed on the delivery unit at the time product is offered for final certification. This examination is limited to defects which may have occurred during handling and storage (e.g., crushed, torn, dirty, stained, etc.) The applicable AMS Visual Aids for Inspection of Containers shall be used by the AMS agent as a reference when determining the severity of container defects.

For production lots of less than 50 shipping containers or less than 300 primary containers, the containers shall be examined individually and all defective containers must be replaced or corrected, as applicable.

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5. PREPARATION FOR DELIVERY

5.1 Packaging, packing, and marking requirements.

5.1.1 Packaging. The bulk ground products (Types I and II) shall be packaged in moisture-vapor proof plastic bags or casings normally used for packaging bulk ground products. Filled casings or bags shall be reasonably uniform in size. Practically all the air shall be worked out through the open end of the filled casings and closed by means of metal clips, tying, or folding to completely cover the product. Coarse ground beef (Type V) shall be bulk packed in wax lined shipping containers without bags or liners.

Patties (Types III and IV) which are individually quick frozen (IQF) shall be: (1) packaged in layers with a sheet of waxed paper or plastic material normally used for this purpose between layers; or (2) placed on waxed patty paper prior to freezing and may be subsequently stacked with or without dividers between stacks.

Patties which are not IQF shall be arranged in stacks, and each patty within a stack shall be separated from adjacent patties by 2 sheets of waxed patty paper. The stacks shall be separated from each other by a full height divider constructed from paperboard.

Stacked patties may be bagged. When bagged, each stack shall be enclosed in a plastic bag of sufficient length to provide adequate closure to protect the product. For layered patties or when individual stacks are not bagged: (1) The container shall be lined with a plastic bag of sufficient size to completely line the interior of the box; (2) The open end of the bag shall be of sufficient length to provide adequate overlap when both sides of the bag are folded along the center of the length of the container; and (3) A sheet of plastic shall be placed to completely cover the top of all the packed stacks of patties prior to closing the plastic box liner.

NOTE: Except when individual stacks are bagged, the full height divider shall be treated to prevent adherence to the stacked patties.

5.1.2 Packing.

a. Unless otherwise specified, products shall be packed as follows:

- The purchaser shall specify the number of filled bags or casings of bulk ground products which shall be snugly packed to the designated net weight.

- Patties shall be snugly packed to a net weight of 36 pounds (16.3 kg).

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- Unless otherwise specified, coarse ground beef (Type V) shall be packed (without bags or liners) to a net weight of 60 pounds without slackfilling or overfilling.

b. Products shall be packed into nonperforated shipping containers without slackfilling or overfilling (spacers or fillers may not be used to satisfy this requirement). Containers may be of any style and shall meet the minimum requirements for Class domestic corrugated fiberboard (Type CF) or solid fiberboard (Type SF) with a minimum bursting strength of 275 psi. However, only one style and size of container may be used in any delivery unit. The AMS agent shall use the boxmaker's certificate label to determine minimum bursting strength. The interiors of the containers for Type V (coarse ground beef) shall be coated with wax or an acceptable wax substitute sufficient to assure container integrity until the product is used. Shipping containers shall be examined for condition at the time of production and at the time the delivery unit is offered for final certification out of the freezer.

Fiberboard containers shall be closed using one or a combination of the following methods:

Strapping - Lengthwise and girthwise straps shall be applied as follows:

1. Lengthwise - Regular slotted containers shall have 2 straps placed over the outer flaps. All other containers 9.0 inches (22.8 cm) or more in outside width shall have 1 strap.

2. Girthwise - Containers 20.0 inches (50.8 cm) or less in outside length shall have 1 strap; containers more than 20.0 inches (50.8 cm) in outside length shall have 2 straps. Containers which have been assembled using the side tuck lock method shall have 2 straps, 1 placed over each of the tuck lock areas. The straps on all other containers shall be placed to divide the box into units of approximate equal length.

Gluing - A sufficient amount of glue or hot-melt adhesive shall be applied to prevent lifting of edges and corners of the outer flaps.

When telescope containers are used, the final closure shall be in accordance with the above strapping method. When the strapping method is used for final closure of slotted containers that have not been assembled using a tuck lock method: (1) The initial closure shall be secured in accordance with the above gluing method. (2) When full overlap slotted containers are used, both the initial and final closure shall be secured in accordance with the above gluing method.

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NOTE: Staples may not be used for assembly or closure of shipping containers (manufacturer's joint).

c. Filled shipping containers of ground products shall be sealed and stamped in accordance with Meat Grading and Certification Branch Instructions.

NOTE: The AMS agent maintains the right to verify, using appropriate test procedures, that packaging and packing materials comply with these requirements.

5.1.3 For Department of Defense procurements. The following requirements are applicable when specified by the Contracting Officer:

Level B. Not less than a net weight of 51 and not more than a net weight of 55 pounds of bulk ground beef and a net weight of 36 pounds of beef patties, of one type only, shall be packed in a snug-fitting, fiberboard box constructed and reinforced in accordance with Style FTC, minimum grade W5s or W5c of PPP-B-636, except that one lengthwise and one girthwise band shall be applied. Alternatively, a wax-impregnated fiberboard box constructed in accordance with Style RSC, Class I, Type SWCFI, minimum grade 200, of PPP-B-1163, may be used. Closure shall be with a hot-melt adhesive in accordance with the appendix of PPP-B-636. The box shall be reinforced with two lengthwise bands and one girthwise band in accordance with the appendix of PPP-B-636. Reinforcement shall be restricted to nonmetallic strapping or pressure-sensitive adhesive, filament-reinforced tape in accordance with the appendix of PPP-B-636. All reinforcing bands shall be uncolored or of a color which contrasts with black. Each box of patties shall be packed with individual stacks covered with a plastic sheet as specified in 5.1.1.

Level C. Shipping containers shall comply with the National Motor Freight Classification or Uniform Freight Classification, as applicable, except metal fasteners shall not be used in the final closure of the fiberboard boxes. Bulk ground beef shall be packed to a minimum net weight of 51 pounds and a maximum net weight of 55 pounds. Beef patties shall be packed to a net weight of 36 pounds. Each box packed with individual stacks of unbagged patties shall be lined with a plastic bag and the stacks covered with a plastic sheet as specified in 5.1.1.

5.1.4 Marking shipping containers. Shipping containers shall be marked as prescribed in applicable contract or solicitation documents.

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6. NOTES

Any procurement activity outside the Federal Government may utilize this specification or any modification thereof. USDA certification may also be specified by these activities, but modification of the document will not be allowed without appropriate approval from the Food Quality Assurance Staff with a mailing address as follows:

U.S. Department of Agriculture, AMS
Food Quality Assurance Staff
Room 2506, South Building, P.O. Box 96456
Washington, DC 20090-6456

6.1 Procurement data. The procuring agency shall specify in the contract or solicitation document the following, as applicable:

a. Product type (I, II, III, IV, or V).

b. Vegetable protein product:

- Source - if other than soy.
- Type - flour, concentrate, or isolate (If not specified, the type of VPP is an option of the contractor.)
- Physical, flavor, and microbiological characteristics (if other than specified herein).
- Hydration - ratio of water to VPP (if other than specified herein).
- Combination - maximum percent of hydrated VPP in the combined finished product (if other than 20 percent).
- Other ingredients - fortification components, seasonings, binders, etc. (if other than specified herein).
- Other requirements - maximum sodium or potassium levels, etc.

c. Net weight and number of bags or casings of bulk ground beef products (Types I and II).

d. Applicable handling and storage requirements (if other than specified herein).

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e. Fat content (if other than specified herein) and discount range, if any.

f. Weight of patties.

g. Shape of patties (if other than specified herein).

h. Plate size thickness (if other than specified herein).

i. Patty count (if other than specified herein) and discount range, if any.

j. Packaging and packing requirements (if other than specified herein).

k. Shipping container markings.

l. Offer unit size.

m. Requirement for microbiological testing (if desired).

MILITARY INTERESTS:

Military Coordinating Activity

Army - GL

Custodians

Army - GL
Navy - SA
Air Force - 50

Review Activities

Army - MD, QM
Navy - MC
DP - SS

CIVIL AGENCY COORDINATING ACTIVITIES:

DOJ - BOP
HHS - FDA, IHS
USDA - FV
VA - OSS

PREPARING ACTIVITY:

USDA - LS

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